

done, you can start capturing content with your card. We didn't have any driver or software issues when testing these cards. Aviosys also did well—there were no configuration, or driver installation issues. The Aviosys application needs to look a whole lot better though. Don't expect to be able to plug in this card and start capturing content immediately, as learning your way around the application will take some effort.

The Pixelview cards had some major drawbacks in terms of driver support and software incompatibility. The PixelView PlayTV PRO crashed our test system till a driver update came to our rescue. The native PixelView application takes a little getting used to, but the bundled PowerVCR software more than makes up for that. The irritating bit is that you need to get the native software settings right before configuring PowerVCR. The Compro and Mercury cards also didn't work out of the box, and needed a driver update and a patch fix in order to work.

Features

All the cards supported stereo capturing, and had the S-Video and Composite input ports. Certain features, such as NICAM stereo, were only provided on the Aviosys, Compro and Pinnacle cards. The Compro card could achieve advanced tasks such as bringing the PC out of standby for a scheduled recording, and then shutting down after the recording is completed.

TV TUNER CARD			
Pixelview	Pixelview	Pixelview	PixelView
PlayTV PRO	Play TV PRO Ultra	PlayTV USB PRO	PlayTV XP
Conexant BT878	Conexant Fusion878	Conexant Fusion878	Conexant Fusion878A
Internal	Internal	External	Internal
✓/✗	✓/✓	✓/✗	✓/✓
✓	✓	✓	✗
✓/✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓/✓
640 x 480	720 x 576	640 x 480	640 x 480
✓	✓	✗	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓
✗	✗	✗	✗
Cyberlink PowerVCR	Cyberlink PowerVCR	Cyberlink PowerVCR	WinDVR, PowerDirector SE
✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓
3/3/3	3/3/3	3/3/3	3/3/3
2	3	3	0
78	78	78	78
✓	✓	✓	✗
21	22	21	21
3/3	4/3.5	3/3	3/3
14.50	15.82	13.42	16.50
47.50	53.50	41.50	51.50
62.00	69.32	54.92	68.00
2.38	2.48	1.22	1.84
2,600	2,800	4,500	3,700
Ⓡ	Ⓡ	Ⓒ	Ⓡ

Mercury TV Tuner Card

The price is right

The Mercury TV Tuner Card is the most widely available card in the market. It's ideal for those who just want to watch TV on their computer, with no fancy trimmings. However, this card does capture content, and can also play the late night FM for you. As for the section that pertains to TV signals, channel-scanning ran into problems, but the driver fix resolved that.



The application that comes bundled keeps crashing, unless you get the update from their Web site. The interface is unintuitive, but clear. New users will take some time to get used to it, and configure the channels. You can save your channel preferences after detecting them. Also, remember to fine-tune after the channel scan for proper display. You can even make a list of your favourite channels in a particular order, and leave out the rest. It lets you take snapshots, but doesn't provide a matrix of them showing all the channels at a glance.

FM-reception is pretty good, but cannot be captured. You can also connect devices such as PlayStation2 and video cameras to this card using the S-Video or composite inputs to play games, or edit video. Content capturing was not up to the mark, and it definitely suffered when trying to capture images at a resolution of 640 x 480—the maximum value that it can go to in Ulead. Priced the lowest at Rs 1,700, it's based on the aging Philips 7130 chip with a Philips tuner. Though it's a plain card with no frills and features, it's definitely easy on the pocket, with decent capturing to boot.

The PixelView cards offered standard MPEG-1 and MPEG-2 capture, except the USB PRO, which lacked MPEG-2 capture capability. The native PixelView application needs a bit of getting used to, and Cyberlink PowerVCR gives you the freedom of shutting down the PC after a scheduled recording.

Only Pinnacle and Compro offered software to convert captured content between formats. All the TV Tuners, except the Pixelview USB PRO and Pinnacle PCTV Plus, provided FM tuners. The Mercury video card lost out on features, as it only

